Anurag Kashyap owned September and how. Toronto saw the world premiere of *Bandar*, his feature with Bobby Deol; Venice saw *Song of Forgotten Trees*—on which he served as executive producer—make waves and win best director prize for Anuparna Roy; and he was co-producer on the critically-acclaimed Tamil drama *Bad Girl*. But it's *Nishaanchi* that Kashyap is most excited about for now. "It's my most *filmi* film," he says with a boyish smile. "It's the one I'm most attached to and happy with the outcome of." Starring Aaishvary Thackeray, Vedika Pinto and Monika Panwar, the drama released in cinemas on September 19.

Even with a studio-backed film like *Nishaanchi*, Kashyap does what he is best known for—flaunting his independent spirit by centring his film on the shoulders of a newcomer, as he did with Kay Kay Menon (*Paanch*), Vineet Kumar Singh (*Mukkabaaz*) or on underutilised talent like Rahul Bhat (*Ugly*, *Kennedy*) and Nawazuddin Siddiqui (*Gangs of Wasseypur*). Here, Mumbai-based Aaishvary in his debut essays the double role of twins from Kanpur who are at odds with each other and Panwar plays mother to the boys. "It comes from the fact that I have seen it work," says Kashyap of his penchant to trust those ignored or looking for a break. "In *Satya*, everyone barring Urmila [Matondkar] was an outsider including the director [Ram Gopal Varma]. It gave me the confidence that when there is intention, it works."

Ramu gave Kashyap wings as a writer but these days it's the name that Kashyap's critics most resort to in a detrimental way as they compare Ramu's rapid downfall to Kashyap's own career in the past decade. Kashyap's glory spell, which included *Black Friday*, *Dev D* and *Gangs of Wasseypur*, ended with the debacle that was *Bombay Velvet*. It's not that Kashyap has made bad films since then (*Ugly*, *Mukkabaaz*, *Manmarziyaan* are proof of his directorial panache and astute commentary on society); it's just that his works are no longer part of the zeitgeist as his earlier works were. In fact, *Kennedy*—his last feature—still awaits a release. "I get written off—*'yeh toh khatam ho gaya* [he's done and dusted]'," he says. "When I talk, they are like he is going RGV 2.0 way. It does affect me when it comes from within the industry. But I know what I am doing." At a time when the Hindi film industry struggles to deliver hits consistently, Kashyap senses an "opportunity". "I know how to work with low budgets, the industry doesn't," he notes. "I'd warn the industry, but they'll see it as whining."

> In ***Nishaanchi***, Aaishvary essays the double role of twins from Kanpur who are at odds with each other



For *Nishaanchi*, producers Amazon MGM trusted Kashyap's vision and, more so, his credentials. "The way they are backing it feels good," he says. "In 32 years of being in this industry, this kind of faith has really been shown only twice before (*Dev D* and *Gangs of Wasseypur*)." The film is all the more significant for Kashyap as it helped him get out of "the black hole" he had gone into. "It's a film where I have found myself, with my people holding me together," he adds.

Apart from filmmaking, the process of self-discovery has also seen Kashyap make a few key changes. He shifted from Mumbai to Bengaluru, and has started actively working as an actor in the southern film industry, with credits including *Maharaja* (Tamil) and *Rifle Club* (Malayalam). He's especially all praise for the Kerala film industry. "There is a beautiful world there where people are talking cinema and supporting each other," he says, citing the likes of actor-producers Tovino Thomas, Fahadh Faasil and Dulquer Salman. "They are all so collaborative, and not jealous of each other's success. Every-